Zeeshan. I felt terrible that a fellow teammate I had had a war of words with over some stupid locker-room row was now in deep trouble.

Zeeshan and I were quite opposites when it came to our cricket, particularly our batting. He was a classic, orthodox batsman. I was certain that he had a bright future ahead of him. Maybe it was our altercation that made me step up and try to be a hero or something. I volunteered and became a witness on his behalf, ready to say that it was the woman's fault entirely, even though I didn't know much about what had happened between them and I doubted him too.

So, there I was, ready to falsely testify to save a teammate. I know it may sound terrible and immature, even dishonest, to admit to it today, but I was just a kid who wanted to stand up for a mate who had obviously screwed up and had a lot to lose in terms of future prospects. It's what young men have always done for other young men in battle and in trouble, even if it doesn't sound right or make any sense. It's just the way some of us are. It's ridiculously childish behaviour but that's the thing: we were children and we thought we were right.

Eventually, thank God, there was no need for my testimony. It all worked out for Zeeshan – the court in Kingston acquitted him for lack of evidence. Though I'm not morally comfortable about it today, I was very proud then to have offered to help out a teammate in trouble. My motives were, without a doubt, well intentioned, even though the act – never committed by me – was, allegedly, a dishonourable one. Thank God for the West Indies judiciary.

As for the series, it went on as per schedule. I remember, in Barbados I picked up 22 wickets in three matches and put some solid runs on the board too. Things were going well for me on the field. Eventually, from the mix of one-day and three-day matches, we would win two, lose two and draw five.

Then, one morning, I was brushing my teeth and getting ready for the day's game when Haroon Rasheed called me and said, 'Congratulations, Shahid. Your name has come up for consideration for the Pakistan team.'

I don't know if it was the earth that moved beneath my feet or if I was shaken to the core. But on hearing him say those words, I was stunned. My toothbrush, still in my mouth, remained there, frozen. All I could reply, in sheer disbelief, was a muffled, 'What?!'

It was a genuine question. Amidst the scandal and the excitement of our own series, I hadn't kept track of happenings in the national team. On tour in Africa, the Pakistani team was hurting in Kenya. Mushtaq Ahmed, the best spinner in the side – maybe in the world at the time – was injured. Considering my recent performance in the series in West Indies, I had been selected to replace him.

When Haroon Rasheed called to tell me about it, I initially thought he was joking, although I was too scared to ask if he was. But once he told me the boring details – travel, paperwork – I realized he was serious. When he began telling me about my next steps – catching the right flights, picking up some gear from Karachi and joining the national team in Kenya – my immediate reaction was fear. I was terrified. How would I deal with the pressure? Would I play with the likes of Wasim Akram, Waqar Younis and Inzamam-ul-Haq? Weren't they supposed to give you prior notice and prepare you before calling you to join the national team? Didn't you have to attend a class or two? Weren't they supposed to give you more time? But wait: this was my dream since I was a kid. So why was I scared? Wasn't this the realization of my dream, to hang out with these legends in the dressing room, play alongside them, be one of them, be like